

■ By Lakshmi Subramanian

**She has received death threats. She has been beaten with shoes. She has been called the Taslima Nasreen of Tamil Nadu. Worse, she has even been declared anti-Muslim. Nothing, though, has deflected her from her chosen path of empowering Muslim women and helping them fight for their basic rights. The face of the Indian**

Muslim woman, Daud Sharifa Khanam, has already formed the Tamil Nadu women's jamaat (a community of elders, almost always male, at village mosques who adjudicate on family matters). It was formed at a convention at Karumandapam in Tiruchy in February 2004. Now she hopes to fulfill her grand dream, a mosque for women.

It hasn't been easy. A post-graduate in history and office management from Aligarh Muslim University, Khanam first came to limelight when she decided to take up the cause for a woman-only mosque. When she started out, she had no idea about the tough time she was in for as she had always lived in a middle-class cocoon. It was only when she began field studies on the condition of Muslim women in Pudukkottai in Tamil Nadu that the seed of revolt germinated. Later on, she identified 12,000 child labourers who were engaged in 73 different types of occupation during her two-year stint as the coordinator of National Child Labour Project in the district. In 1998, she quit that job and decided to help the women who had suffered under self-styled godman Premananda, who was

later convicted for murdering and raping several women in Tamil Nadu.

Then came her moment. In 1991, she established STEPS, an NGO devoted to the cause. Initially, even Khanam was doubtful of her success. But her resolve was only strengthened when she saw Muslim women

**WOMEN'S OWN:**  
Khanam at the mosque's  
construction site



**femini  
FORCE**

✱ D. Sharifa Khanam

Project STEPS is an NGO which takes care of women's education. It has also set up a first all-women's cooperative in 15 of the 31 taluqs in Tamil Nadu.

Can-do Icon Halime Bibi because she is self-reliant.

The literacy rate for women in the country is

**50.1 per cent** compared to the national figure of **53.7**

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**I want Muslim women to have their own space to talk, discuss their grievances and pray. They should have a say in community rulings.**

**SHARIFA KHANAM, Founder, STEPS**

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